

■ By Jhilmil Motihar and Kaverie Bamzai

For those wondering why their television channels are suddenly spewing sameness, here's a tip. Look behind the scenes. The series of small town daughters who have started making an appearance on Star Plus, from *Bidaai* to *Raja Ki Aayegi Baraat*, have something to do with the team that is creating them—led by Vikas Bahl, the man who crafted the circuit breaking *Saat Phere* on Zee TV. The team that currently guides fortunes at NDTV Imagine is almost entirely made up of the Star Plus diaspora. And when they pulled *Ramayan* out of the hat, those they had left behind at Star Plus dusted *Mahabharata* off its two-year-old mothballs and quickly announced it to cash in on a yet another me-too move. Such is the similarity that channels are even running out of guests for their reality shows. Ronit and Rohit Roy, brothers who were host and participant in Sony's *Jhalak Dikhla Jaa 2* are now participants in 9X's *Yeh Hai*

STOP OR THE VIEWER WILL

Two new channels have not infused novelty into the general entertainment genre. Ratings as well as genre shares have fallen to the depths that me-too creativity has already descended.

EPIC CLONES ▶▶▶



● When *Ramayan* got NDTV Imagine a good start, Star Plus pulled out *Mahabharata*.

● Sahara One took no time in producing *Neeli Aankhen* after Zee TV's *Naagin* started doing decently on the TRP charts.

Jalwa, which also stars Prachi Desai, who won *Jhalak Dikhla Jaa 2*, and Rakhi Sawant, fresh out of yet another dance show, *Nach Baliye 3*. Saroj Khan, a celebrity judge on *Nach Baliye 3*, has her own show on NDTV Imagine now, *Nachle Ve*.

The results of this famine of ideas are there for all to see. Audiences are split down the middle between Star Plus and Zee, whose channel shares in the week ended March 1 were 29 per cent and 27 per cent respectively, according to Television Audience Measurement (TAM). In the same week, while Star Plus had 10 shows in the top 20, Zee TV had eight. Despite the launch of two new channels in the past six months, the general entertainment genre is at its smallest ever, having

SAGA OF BOREDOM ▶▶▶

- The share of Hindi general entertainment channels has fallen from 21.3 per cent in 2004 to 20.2 per cent in 2007
- The highest rated show for the week ended on March 1 was *Banoo Main Teri Dulhann* on Zee TV at 4.7, compared to the week ended March 1 in 2006, when it was *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi* at 9
- Star Plus which leads with *saas-bahu* sagas and Zee TV which leads with dramatic daughters are neck and neck in the top 100 shows, with Star Plus leading with 35 shows and Zee TV with 29

Source: TAM